

Shadows of Titan

The moment the buzzer went off, his boots left the platform and the world exploded around him. Blazing fire shot from both sides as he twisted mid-air, landing along a metal spine wider than his foot. Sparks burst beneath his weight, and the cheering from the spectators grew to a frenzy as it started to collapse. He felt the magma in his veins ignite as he launched off the spine into the frenzy of contestants below. With blissful brutality, he began ruthlessly slashing through the contestants with his magma blade. No reasons, no teams, just pure adrenaline and blood.

Chapter 10

Moving her things to the Apex wing didn't take long. One trip, actually. She didn't have much, but it was obvious these quarters were made for a surplus of personal paraphernalia. She made a note to herself to buy some clothes. It wouldn't fit in for an Apex to wear the same thing every week, she mused. She fiddled with the crystal-glow lighting and the atmosphere simulator before sitting on the bed. It didn't dip or creak. She wanted to call Vexal. Wanted to hear his voice, but she had no idea what kind of security these rooms had. It didn't seem like the AAN would let their most expensive toys have too much privacy.

She stood when she heard her comtech chime. Dinner hour, but there was no way in Titan she was walking into the Apex mess hall. She would still eat with the cadets, and she didn't mind

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the walk there. It gave her time to look at the different art that lined the walls, especially the different glittering busts and statues of Apexes long gone.

She found Taryn, Synn, and Bryn already halfway through their plates. They made room for her instantly.

“Tell me they didn’t already kick you out!” Taryn groaned, laughing.

Synn floated by and flicked her shoulder. “She misses us! Of course she misses us!”

Nyx smiled. “I missed you guys.”

They cheered and she dug in, slipping easily into the rhythm of the conversation. She hadn’t realised how tense she had been on the Apex side, but here at least it felt somewhat familiar. After they finished eating, they grabbed couches and cushions from their rooms and made a lounge area behind the dinner table.

“This is nice,” Taryn said, sinking back into the upholstered couch with a grin. “Much better than solitary confinement.”

“Your room is **not** like solitary confinement, Taryn,” Synn said, flopping down on some cushions. “But yes, this is better than our rooms.”

Nyx murmured her agreement as Bryn sank down into the shadows around some cushions, his feet hanging over the back of the couch.

They stayed like that well into the night, laughing together, teasing each other, discussing their days. When she finally returned to her room, Nyx couldn’t help but glance at the door across from hers. It was still firmly shut and she couldn’t help but wonder if Darius was behind it. Sleeping? Brooding, probably. He didn’t talk much and seemed less than thrilled to have her assigned as a partner.

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This hadn't been the plan, exactly; she needed time to learn the rhythm of the place, to blend in. But now she was here and she wanted to call Vexal, but she didn't dare. She hoped whoever his contact on the inside would let him know where she was. It would definitely be a while before she could visit home.

She slid beneath the sleek covers of her new bed and tried not to think. When sleep finally came, it was shallow and dark.

She woke to the gentle chime of her comtech. Thirty minutes before training hour. She groaned; it was barely oh-five-hundred hours.

"Too early," she muttered under her breath, but she got moving. The room felt neither cold nor warm, and she stretched languidly before she started dressing. She forced herself to look awake as she made her way to the Dominion Training Grounds. She had no idea what to expect and hadn't seen Darius on the way, so she figured he was probably waiting for her. She hurried her steps and made it with a good ten minutes to spare.

As she stepped through the massive obsidian doors, she heard the combat floor hiss with steam and pressurised steel. The lights overhead were bright white, illuminating the whole arena in a harsh glare. She noted the reinforced alloy panels lining the walls. They hummed faintly with the sound of containment fields.

At the far end, Darius turned and strode toward her. His striking face covered in sweat and his arms and chest coursed with Magma veins and scars. His gaze was locked on hers as he approached. "I hope you're ready," his deep voice rumbled slightly out of breath from his training. "Because I won't be holding back. Not only do I need to see you in combat, but we also need to see if we can synergise."

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Nyx nodded. “Understood,” she said simply. He stepped back and rolled his shoulders, sparks leaping from his gauntlets. Heat began pouring off him in waves, rippling through the air. The floor beneath him sizzled and Nyx braced herself.

“The first move is yours,” he said, his eyes flaring.

She didn’t wait for more. She twisted the floor beneath him violently, sending dozens of jagged metallic spikes upward with a thunderous crack. Darius launched into the air over them, his entire frame ignited in a pulse of volcanic heat, Magma flaring from his fist. They melted as he touched the ground.

He turned and charged at her without missing a beat, swinging a gauntlet full of Magma at her with startling force. She warped out of the space and reappeared behind him, her hand already outstretched, twisting a barrage of high-velocity metallic shards that launched at him like silver spears.

Darius spun, and with a snarling smile, he detonated. A shockwave of molten energy burst from his body, incinerating the projectiles mid-air. He smirked at her. “Is that all?” he challenged.

She could feel the heat radiating off him. Did he look almost... happy?

She didn’t respond as a wave of molten rock surged at her. She exerted her energy, holding it even though it pushed her back slightly. She let it turn to dust in her hands before letting her fist connect with his stomach, sending him flying backward from the force.

He growled, catching himself before he launched at her again, coming in low and fast, trails of Magma streaking behind him. She dodged his first two blows, then warped him high in the air before slamming the Magma she had absorbed back into him. He hit the ground with a thunderous crack, buried beneath the molten rock. He exploded out, Magma flying, a wild grin

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on his face as he leapt into the air. His strikes only came faster now, laughter bellowing out of him.

She didn't have time to question it. Dark energy unfurled from her palms, transforming a section of the arena into living thorns of obsidian that coiled and struck like snakes. She warped the battlefield with illusions, reshaped barriers, but nothing held him.

He burned hotter and hotter, clashing with her power again and again. No matter what she threw at him, he simply laughed and egged her on with cutting jabs. Alarms kicked on briefly as the arena began to shudder, the strain of their combined powers almost too much for it. Sweat pricked her back and she knew she had to switch tactics, but no matter what she did he met her head-on, that wild smile across his face.

When the second alarm went off, he skidded to a stop and raised his hand. She immediately began fixing the arena. In a heartbeat it was back in pristine condition, and she breathed a sigh of relief. She was out of breath, and he was steaming and smouldering, yet still grinning at her.

"Now that's what I call a fight!" he said, punching his fist into his palm a few times and cracking his shoulders. He eyed the fixed arena and nodded once.

"Time to synergise," he said, his voice steady. "If the heat gets too much, you pull out immediately."

Nyx nodded once. "Understood," she said, but she could feel her cheeks warm.

Darius studied her for a beat. "Have you ever synergised before?"

"No," she answered.

His brow furrowed at that, lips pressing into a thin line. But he didn't say anything and motioned for her to follow.

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“It’s how we align our energy signatures,” he explained as they walked to the centre of the arena. “We let our powers flow and find rhythm with each other. I normally can only sync with people who can handle extreme heat. King. Ei... Solaris.” He cleared his throat. “I let the Magma flow and they choose how much they can take.” He shrugged, but there was a gravity in his words.

Nyx nodded again, understanding better this time. “I understand,” she lied.

“Since this is your first time,” he said, “we will take it slow.”

She nodded and raised her hands, pushing her energy out to him uncertainly. She felt his energy immediately, like a pulse exploding between them. Her energy surged to meet his and Darius’s chest and core flared, his Magma veins instantly glowing brighter, hotter. His back arched as the power surged through him, his tan skin radiating white with the heat, his gauntlets groaning against the strain.

He roared, slamming his fist into the floor. A shockwave cracked through the arena, spiderwebbing through the walls like they were made of glass. Fire licked up around them in colossal spirals of molten energy, bleeding into the infrastructure.

Nyx staggered, her breath catching in her throat as she pushed to contain the fallout. Her Temporal energy pulsed outward like a second wave, slowing the structural damage, holding the shattered alloy plates in place as Darius exploded into the air like a Solar flare.

It felt so different from Vexal’s power. His rot, his corrosion, his madness clung to every part of her. But Darius burned with an all-consuming white fire. She could feel his power riding hers, amplifying as she fed into him. He flew through the air, pulling her along with him in a tide of combustion and blue flames. The arena couldn’t take it; the containment field began to warp and the floor became a lake of molten alloy. Alarms were going off at max volume, but he didn’t

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stop. She felt her heartbeat in her ears and her eyes felt hot. She could barely see, but she could feel the eyes on them as the observation decks opened. Emergency klaxons flared as he blasted a final thunder burst of Solar fire that tore a hole clean through the rear arena wall. The Dominion shields shuddered. Nyx immediately pulled back and tried to steady the arena as Darius still hovered slightly above the floor in a flaming human inferno. She tried her best with her transformation to recast the damage, but it was insignificant and she was genuinely unsure of what she was doing.

She heard boots hit the solidifying floor behind her and turned just as Darius swept her off her feet with a laugh. His eyes were still fiery-bright and his hands were so hot it hurt her sides, but she couldn't help but laugh, too. He caught himself and put her down gently. "I'm sorry," he said, still breathless. "I didn't mean... that was..." He shook his head. "That was incredible!" he said finally.

She smiled at him, still trying to catch her breath as well. The heat between them made her heartbeat faster and she tried to ignore it. "Is it like this every time you synergise?" she asked, laughing. The arena was already filling up with techs to repair the damage as the alarm lights finally blinked off.

"Not at all," he said, flicking her on the shoulder lightly. He looked like he was going to say something else, but he stepped back and nodded to the door. "You should definitely eat up. And rest. We're patrolling tomorrow. I'll send you the routes to study."

She nodded, and he turned and jogged off, leaving her to her own thoughts. She exhaled, stretching away the tension as she made her way back to her room. Her body still felt like it was on fire, but it wasn't the heat. Something about Darius felt so... intoxicating. She shook her head

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as she started the shower. She needed to cool off before she went to the mess hall. Her body and her mind.

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Darius stepped into the steaming shower, stripped off the tattered remains of his training suit, and let the scalding water burn over his skin. His veins pulsed faintly beneath the surface, humming with energy. Synergising always left residual energy, a phantom hum in his nerves, but this felt different.

Synergy. He'd done it with his previous partners before, of course. Eira, even King on occasion, but this. This was different. His body still felt high from it, the power rush, the connection. His flames had found something in her and she was the first person who had been able to handle his inferno. Not just handling; it didn't even bother her. It seemed, if anything, it fed her as much as it did him. Synergising always created intensity, sure. Sharing wavelengths, the emotional bleed-over from the physical intimacy, but it had never been this volatile. This *addictive*. He hadn't told her the whole truth about synergising since it seemed she had lied. She hadn't even heard of it, let alone thought to try it. It was such a commonplace action he hadn't

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even thought about it this hard before. His jaw clenched at the thought, she was either raised extremely sheltered or by fanatics.

He turned the water as cold as it would go and stood under the freezing barrage. After he had suggested synergising and she had held out her hands, he knew she didn't know what he was talking about and he didn't want to be the one to explain intimacy to her. He never had that reaction without being physical with someone. She had somehow fueled his power without even touching him; actually synergising with her would be a full wrecking detonation.

He shook his head hard, flexing his hands, trying to calm his rising pulse. Synergy always messes with emotions, everyone knows that. He needed to pull himself together. He stepped out, drying off and dressing in a clean AAN tunic, slipping his gauntlets back into place. He never went anywhere without it. It was the one guaranteed way he could control his energy, and he would need all the control in his core for this.

His boots clacked against the polished floor in a familiar way as he made his way to the briefing room through the lower hall, a trick he used to avoid the errant reporter or overzealous Echelon cadet. As expected, King was already there, arms folded, Solar threads pulsing in his chest like a ticking star. The door was barely sealed behind him when King started.

"They sent me the training footage," he snapped, teeth tight. "**All of it.** Want to tell me why the Dominion training arena looks like it was flashcracked by a rogue Dreg?"

The screen behind King flared to life, stuttering with the chaotic remnants of their training session. Molten blasts, warped alloy sagging like ribbons, Nyx mid-air, her white hair whipping around her in a beautiful frenzy. Darius felt a pull in his gut he ignored. "She tried to fix it," he said calmly. "She held the arena together as best as she could."

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“She’s **unstable!**” King snarled. “We can’t afford levelling-building-type liabilities. What if a cadet had wandered in? What if she’d voided the central power grid?” He tossed a datapad across the desk. “Your Mutation Index has climbed past what protocol allows for your Tier. You’re past containment thresholds. You are a walking bomb, **Valkyrie.**”

Darius didn’t even read the datapad. “Then maybe raise my Tier.”

King flared, his Solar aura blooming in a blinding pulse that rattled the walls. “You two together are too dangerous!” he bellowed.

Jealousy looks so vrecking petty on you, King, Darius thought. He wanted to say it as King lunged for the desk and launched it across the room, sending datapads and maps flying into the wall. Darius didn’t flinch as King spun towards him, seething.

“Did you learn her weaknesses?” he practically spat out.

Darius could feel his pulse raise slightly and he took a breath before saying evenly, “No—”

King screamed and began trashing the briefing room in earnest. Chairs, screens, books were all sent flying. A classic Helios tantrum.

Darius didn’t wait to be dismissed. He saluted and left, the door whispering shut behind him as he passed Eira on the way in, ice already forming along the floor in her wake.

Let her calm him down. He had better things to do than babysit Sunflare’s ego. Back in his quarters, Darius stripped down again and stood before the mirror. The veins along his shoulders still glowed brightly with residual energy, brighter than they had in many cycle years. He flexed his hand, the Magma thread shimmering like liquid gold. Nyx’s mutation hummed beneath his skin, wild and alive.

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Tiering up was rare at his age but not impossible. Synergy usually boosted one person, certainly not both. That made it dangerous. Addictive. He needed to see the doctor, but he hated that rat-brained weasel. Gave him the hives with how intently he watched him during tests. Instead, he keyed in a location on his comtech:

HELIX SPIRE: AETHERION BIO-LABS. DR. RHEA VAELITH.

If anyone could read what was happening to him without directly selling it to the Council, it was Rhea. He dressed quickly and launched his transport, gliding over the veined archways of Dominion HQ before shooting into the open sky. The transport lanes spiralled upward like veins of neon across the Titan skyline.

Soon the city of Aetherion stretched below. It glittered in threads of gold and spectral blue. A city built to reflect the heavens, a gleaming contradiction of order and chaos. Gravlift loops criss-crossed between elegant glass towers, spiralling sky-pools shimmered in anti-gravity rings, and the Helix Spire soared above it all. Home to Titan's most advanced biological research, it pulsed and shimmered with activity and life.

He passed over the Spore Gardens, where vision-quests turned men mad and lovers walked barefoot through hallucinations. Further out, distant flashes marked the Ashbreaks, reminding him it would probably be a while before he went back. He loved causing damage but he wasn't stupid and didn't want to level half of Forgedeep just because he got a little flashcracked.

The transport clamped with a soft hiss as Darius stepped out. He had come to Rhea Vaelith's private duty wing directly instead of the public floor; he didn't need half of the medical

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force knowing he was here. Her research sanctum was alive with vascular walls, humming with a low pulse of Chlorokinetic current. It smelled fresh, like oxygen and soil, and he inhaled deeply. He didn't knock. He never did. They'd known each other for many cycle years. Through Apex assignments. Warzones. Quiet conversations at midnight after brutal rescue ops. She'd once offered to synergise with him, but he had gently and respectfully turned her down. He couldn't risk burning her, and the thought of hurting her actually made him emotional.

Inside, the sanctum breathed with the soft rhythm of plant-coded machinery. Darius found her hunched over a sprawling vascular specimen, something biolaced with dormant spores he couldn't recognise that made her even more striking green skin gleam beneath the pale light. Her aura calmed him, soft and earthy, her quiet strength radiating off of everything she touched. He didn't speak and waited patiently, breathing in the sweet air.

Eventually, she turned. Her long fingers moved with the fluidity of a trained surgeon as she removed her coat, revealing a moss-toned gown beneath that shimmered like living leaves. She tilted her head, that sly, musical accent curling into the air like a lullaby. "Well, well." She smiled up at him. "What trouble do you bring me today, Darius?"

He smirked faintly and shook his head. "No trouble today. Just... a check-up."

That earned her full attention. Her rich, gold and green eyes narrowed at him. "A check-up," she said.

"I got a new partner and we... I synergised," he said, choosing his words carefully. "Sort of."

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She didn't interrupt. Just turned and reached for her resonance scanner. A sleek, vine-wrapped device designed to read mutation volatility, energy spikes, and neural integrity. It unfolded like a blooming ocher flower.

He exhaled slowly. "We didn't even touch."

She stopped in her place abruptly. Her eyebrows shot upward and for a moment, she stared at him like he had just cursed the forbidden scriptures. "What do you mean? How is that even..?"

"I don't know," he said, rubbing the back of his neck. "But it did something to me. More than normal."

He described in detail what happened in the arena, from the heat, the surge, the General losing it afterwards. As he spoke, the scanner pulsed against his chest, logging readings that Rhea muttered to herself while her expression went from confused, to alarmed, to absolutely enthralled.

"Darius. It seems you spiked into Quasar-tier thresholds. Look at this." She flicked the holoprojection toward him. The readout glowed bright orange-red, pulsing with overlapping spirals of energy readings. "That level of harmonised combustion? That doesn't happen outside of some very strong sync-bonding. And certainly not without some kind of contact. Did you even get this kind of output with King?"

He shook his head. "Not even close."

Rhea stared at the scanner like it might be broken. "Do you mind if I call Kael?"

Darius gave a shrug. "Go ahead. He hates the AAN more than he hates breathing; I trust him not to open his mouth."

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She tapped her comtech and hailed Kael Dryak while continuing to log his vitals. “Your core temperature is still up. Doubling your resonance baseline. Energy restitution still peaked... and you say you feel fine?”

“I feel great!” he emphasised again.

She turned to her desk, tapping her resonance scanner. “I’d say so. These levels could level a small city. Honestly, Darius? How is this woman not already wrapped up in some diplomatic bond with some high-ranking AAN Council member?”

“About that...” He lowered his voice, putting to words something that deeply troubled him. “She doesn’t seem to know what synergy is. When I said it was time to synergise, she looked at me, raised her hands toward me... Then this happened.” He gestured to his readouts.

“What do you mean, raised her hands?” Kael Dryak’s voice rang from the doorway, catching the tail end of their conversation as he stepped into the room. “What in Titan’s name did I just walk into?”

Kael sauntered over, adaptive armour half-active, rippling with the shimmer of his atmosphere absorption flexing like heat waves around him. Rhea filled him in quickly, handing him the scanner while gesturing toward the different readings.

Kael whistled low. “This is like an insane, permanent flashcrack? You didn’t even graze her and she lit your circuits like this?”

“Didn’t even hesitate,” Darius confirmed. “Didn’t flinch at the heat either. Like it wasn’t there to her.”

Kael exhaled slowly. “No wonder King’s tail is in a twist. You Tiered up. And if you told him you actually didn’t synergise, he’s probably thinking this is only the first Tier up.”

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Rhea nodded solemnly. “I don’t recommend you do it again, Darius. This energy resonance is so... volatile...” She sighed, looking him in the eyes, the flecks of gold sparking. “This is not synergy. It’s a fusion nightmare, and if you did decide to synergise, you could crack the Core if even one of you spun out. And we have no idea how her body reacted at all or even what her limits are...”

Darius didn’t answer. Deep down, he knew it was going to happen again. And he couldn’t ignore the pull she had on him. He wanted to synergise with her, consequence be damned.

“Does she use any adaptive tech?” Kael asked, tapping through his comtech. “Maybe the arena sensors picked up—”

Both Darius and Rhea shook their heads. “None,” Darius reiterated. “Even her uniform seems to be mostly for show. Everything she did came from her. Clean.”

Kael shook his head in disbelief. “She’s a wild node, Darius. Something untethered, no stabilisers, and no known thresholds. And she’s not even sweating it, so she apparently doesn’t know enough about the AAN and Apexes to know this is unusual, at the very least. Something is not right here.”

Rhea walked them back to her desk. “Well, I’ll be damned if I don’t get some kind of answers. Her records are locked tighter than Voxx’s jawline, but maybe I can bypass it through the old Consortium network.”

Darius nodded once. “Thanks. I mean it.”

Rhea placed a soft hand on his wrist, her verdant skin cool against his heat. “Be careful with her, Darius.”

He looked deep into her eyes, but her meaning was unreadable. He nodded again. “That’s the plan,” he said quietly.

Chapter 12

The dorm lights were low, throwing soft shadows across the gleaming floors, but Myth sat in stillness, the polished calm a thin facade. Her eyes felt dulled by fatigue and she stared blankly at nothing; each breath was an effort, shallow and tight. Her limbs ached, but it was deeper than the physical strain. She felt cracked open, hollow.

The sparring match with Darius that morning had used massive amounts of energy. The Temporal warp she used to hold the facility together was all too much, too fast. The Apex Corps didn't know what she was, so they tested her all day, looking for some secret key. But she didn't even know what she was herself. And now she didn't know if she could even stand from her spot on the bed without trembling.

But she had to. She had to move now before it was too late. She stumbled to the showers, pulling out her comtech and typed quickly, the words blurring:

I need to see you. Now.

The reply came instantly:

Come home.

She didn't waste a second. Myth stumbled blindly out to the balcony, the night air brushing against her sweat-slicked skin. Her vision was hazy as she tried to focus her thoughts. Her warping always landed perfectly, but not tonight. The moment she triggered the shift, she felt herself begin to slip. The burn of exhaustion twisted her focus, the world bending wrong beneath her feet. She slammed into the ground with a jarring thud. Her knees buckled and she reached out for something solid as a wave of vertigo spun the world sideways. She knew she was close because the smog burned her lungs, and she could vaguely see the flickering lights ahead. She limped her way to the Big O's metal door, her hand barely able to knock. She didn't have to.

The door burst open. “**Myth,**” Vexal breathed as he caught her, scooping her effortlessly into his arms. His energy radiated around her, cool and heavy, comforting, home.

He carried her inside, down the chaotic hallways and peeling walls. This wasn't the soulless perfection of the Apex dorms, and she hadn't realised how much she missed it until now. He pushed the door to her old room open with his foot and lowered her onto the bed gently. The mattress creaked softly beneath her, and the air wafted faintly of ash, steel, and whatever wildflower soap Lyra had stashed in the laundry closet last week.

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Vexal shut the door and squatted down beside her, his massive frame filling her vision. His grey eyes darkened as they scanned her, shrewdly taking in her shallow breaths and shaking body.

“You’re worse than I expected,” he said finally, his voice heavy with worry.

Myth tried to smile but ended up wincing. “The price of trying to fit in with the Apex Corps,” she quipped.

“Darius pushed you that hard?” his eyebrow shot up.

She gave a slight nod. “Harder than I thought he would for a simple spar.”

Vexal muttered something sharp under his breath. “That idiot doesn't know when to stop,” he finally huffed. “Do you need to feed?” he asked bluntly, his eyes never leaving hers.

The question thudded like a stone in her chest. She dropped her gaze to her hands, her fingers curling in, almost ashamed. She didn’t want to answer, didn’t want to admit it, but they were past the point of pretending.

“Yes,” she whispered. “But... I don’t know if I can keep doing this, Vexal. What if I can’t get back here? What if they—”

He reached out and cupped her face gently with one hand, his calloused thumb stilling her lips. “Then we don’t keep doing this. We find another way. But not tonight. Tonight, you **need** to eat. Because you’re not good to any of us like this, let alone yourself.”

She nodded, her throat too tight to speak.

“Lie down,” he said softly.

She obeyed as he helped her shift flat on the bed. He undid her uniform, careful and slow, then slipped out of his own clothes. His skin was warm and humming with the slow churn of rot

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as he slid behind her, wrapping his powerful arms around her. One arm draped across her middle, his hand steady on her stomach, the other curled around her head, pulling her closer.

His energy flowed into her like wildfire through an oil district. It filled her slowly. Deep, thick, and vital. Her hands gripped his thick forearms, her lips parted in a gasp. The room started to tremble, but Vexal didn't hold back. He surged into her like a tidal wave, unbound, unmeasured. Myth felt it crash through her cell by cell, saturating every hollow piece of her that had been left raw. This wasn't like before; this was almost overwhelming. She realised now how gentle he'd been with her before, how much he had held back.

But not now. Her breath hitched as her body arched sharply, unable to contain the sensations as his dark energy roared through her system. Her skin shimmered with its effects, tendrils of rot slithering along her limbs and coiling with the very being of her mutation. The effect clouded her vision, leaving her hot and panting, wanting more.

She rolled onto him, straddling his waist, feeling his hard length slowly enter her as she lowered herself onto him. Stretching her, filling her up impossibly, the sensations almost making her black out. He reached up, capturing her face and kissing her gently, grinding his length into her. She cried out as his hands gripped her hips, pulling her down onto the full of him. The energy between them had no restraint, his rot pouring into her, his power burning her like a fire.

Vexal groaned against her lips as he steadily moved against her, his body trembling slightly as her power started to pour back into him, her transformation causing his energy to run wild. She almost felt like she couldn't breathe as she felt his hand tangle in her hair, pulling her head back as he kissed her neck and shoulders softly. Her skin started to radiate, the white glow peaking around the tendrils of rot, bright and burning. She couldn't hear anything but the roaring in her ears as she clutched him, her nails dragging against his skin. His body was shaking and

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slicked with sweat as she moved with him, feeling every scar and muscle press against her bare skin, making her want more. Vexal's movements were becoming more erratic as she fed into him, the Big O groaning around them, lights flickering while pipes rattled in the distance as he poured into her. Myth clutched at him, gasping against his skin as he crashed into her a final time with a force that shook the bedframe and buckled the air. Her insides felt like they were exploding and she struggled to keep her screams in, collapsing against him breathless.

Vexal wrapped his arms around her gently, his breath raspy in her ears. He held her gently to him, his heart thrumming loudly in his chest. She tried to steady her breathing, not wanting to part from him, wanting to always feel him like this. It came to an end all too short as he gently pulled out of her, leaving her with a strange empty feeling. He rolled onto his side, one hand propping up his head as he studied her. There was something in his expression that wasn't normally there, something soft and possessive.

She liked it.

"What do you want to do, Myth?" he asked finally, his deep voice steady.

She stared up at the cracked ceiling for a long moment, her fingers brushing over the few errant strands of rot, taking them in. Even just little bits of it felt good, addictive, but made her feel alive.

"I feel incredible," she finally said, almost in a whisper. "Like I could take on all of Titan and not even flinch." She turned her head to meet his gaze. "I don't want to quit. Not yet. I finally have a way in. A path straight to King. If I leave now, I lose everything."

Vexal nodded, the movement small but assuring. "Then that's what we do," he said. "But when you start feeling hungry, you come home. Every time. We will make it work." He paused, then smirked faintly. "Every Apex has their secrets; no reason you can't have yours."

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Myth gave him a nod and lay back down. Vexal reached for her again, pulling her against him. His body still radiated rot, but it felt comforting to her.

“You know I’ll be there,” he murmured against her hair. “Wherever you need me. However you need me.” His voice cracked slightly at the end, and Myth curled closer, tucking her face against his chest.

“Thank you, Vexal,” she said softly.

He exhaled, wrapping both arms around her in a tight embrace. “I could fall asleep like this,” he chuckled. “But you need to get back before they start asking questions.”

She nodded reluctantly, deeply breathing him in, not wanting to let go. With a final squeeze he sat up and she glanced around at the chaos of the room. Rot had twisted the walls, warped the floorboards, shattered the old light fixture. She raised a hand and, with a careful move of her hand, rewrote it all, slowly restoring her room to its usual charmingly dysfunctional state.

Vexal helped her dress, his hands soothing as he adjusted the seams of her uniform, combing through her hair, and brushing off dust here and there. Before she left, he ran a handheld scanner over her, his brow drawn together in concentration.

“No lingering signatures,” he finally confirmed with a smile. “You took it all in clean.”

She smirked up at him. “Of course I did.”

He stepped in close, brushing a kiss against her forehead. Myth’s chest clenched with an ache she didn’t understand. She gave him a small wave as she took a few steps back. And in the next breath she was warping through space in a whisper of silver light, returning to the polished stillness of her Apex balcony like she had never left.

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She paused at the balcony's edge, feeling the persona of Nyx settle over her. The city glittered below, neon veins cutting through the dark glow of Titan's broken skin. The air was sharp this high up, cool against her still-warm skin. She exhaled, slow and steady, grounding herself.

Vexal's energy curled through her like living ink, woven into every cell. She felt... complete. For the first time since arriving, the hunger that had gnawed at her edges was gone. No ache, no need, it was sated... for now at least.

She moved inside with a sigh and let her body fall into the bed. The sheets were cold and smooth. She quickly shed her uniform and crawled beneath them. Her eyes drifted shut before she could worry about tomorrow. No dreams, no burning lights. Just peaceful sleep.

The sunlight spilled into the training facility, catching the gleam of alloy armour and polished boots as the recruits and Apexes stood in tight formation for roll call. The air hummed with quiet tension, a low charge built from too many egos packed into one space. After, as they made their ways to their designated mess halls, she noticed Bryn walking over. His own shadow almost swallowed his footsteps; his eyes were narrowed with a dark look in them.

"You disappeared last night," he said, his voice low and sharp.

Nyx didn't look at him, but she felt a prickle down her spine. She kept her tone flat. "I needed a snack."

Bryn kept pace with her, his eyes not leaving her face. "Campus was locked down. Hard to grab snacks when every corridor's sealed. Even for someone with your tricks."

She met his eyes now, letting her annoyance show. "I'm resourceful."

A pause stretched between them.

"Did you need me for something?" she asked sharply.

Shadows of Titan

He took a step back and shook his head. “Just wanted to check on you.” He said finally as he turned away. “I assumed you were with your partner, but it seems he hadn’t seen you either.”

A chill pricked her skin as Bryn walked away smugly. This was not good. Her good feelings from the night before gave way to cold dread as she thought of what Darius would have to say. By the time patrol began, she had managed to calm her nerves. She was an Apex now. And Apexes were allowed to have secrets.

The city sprawled out beneath their hovercraft, a mess of mid-tier chaos and light. They were in the heart of the Stratos Gate, Titan’s atmospheric corridor where infrastructure mixed with the sky. Towers layered upon towers, neon-lit sky bridges coiled between them, and drones of the silent watchers slicing overhead. The lower levels were all noise and movement, gritty streets filled with merchants’ cries, Luminals and Dregs ducking through the corridors, everyone chasing their own version of survival.

Above them, the sleek towers of the Apex Division cut through the skyline, a stark contrast to the poverty below.

Darius stood beside her, quiet and poised. His molten eyes scanned the chaos below with a soldier’s detachment. He adjusted his gauntlet, the crimson veins of his Magma energy pulsing faintly with restrained fire. “You ready?” he asked without looking at her.

Nyx didn’t answer immediately as she stretched her arms one way then the other. He hadn’t mentioned anything or even acted strange towards her this morning, and she wondered if maybe Bryn had been bluffing. “Ready,” she said, bouncing on her toes.

Darius gave the nod, and the transport dropped into descent with a smooth hiss, the underside thrusters humming against the wind. Below them, Stratos Gate spread out like a

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breathing machine overflowing with rusted platforms layered between polished corridors, street vendors hawking wares beside holographic ads, everything pulsing with barely-contained energy.

“This is your first time out,” Darius said, glancing her way as the wind shifted the air across his face. “Just follow my lead.”

Nyx nodded, her eyes sharp. The transport banked, and as they dropped lower she caught it, the feeling. A hum beneath her skin; something here felt off.

They touched down on a landing terrace just above the main causeway. The moment their boots hit the steps, heads turned. Civilians paused mid-step, conversations clipped, even the traffic drones slowed on their programmed routes.

A cluster of children whispered and pointed. A vendor called out, “About time the Corps sent real muscle!”

Teenagers started nabbing holopics from across the street, zooming in on Nyx, waiting.

Darius chuckled slightly as he stepped off the platform, his armour catching the light. “See, they love you already!”

“We haven’t done anything yet,” Nyx muttered, her gaze scanning the crowd, looking for their target.

“Doesn't matter,” he replied shortly. “To them, we’re gods.”

She said nothing, because in that moment she felt a ripple through the air.

The attack came fast and hard in the midst of screams and crashing stalls. Then there was an explosion of meat and blood as a mutated Dreg tore from the shadows of a narrow alleyway, its body twisting every possible way. Its limbs were bent, elongated and twitching, while its skin pulsed with veins of unstable energy, stretched too tight over muscles that quivered with pain and

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rage. Dozens of eyes blinked along its shoulders, watching from every angle, a howl of agony tearing from its throat.

The sound turned the entire street into chaos. Civilians screamed and scrambled, scattering across the walkways. Market stalls collapsed under the weight of the fleeing bodies, parents grabbed children, everyone sought shelter. Alarms howled overhead as the warnings went out.

“Stay back!” Darius barked at a few stragglers, stepping forward as fire burst from his shoulders, his molten veins surging with power.

Nyx moved fast; her hand sliced through the air and the ground beneath the Dreg buckled and twisted into jagged black spikes that speared it into place. The creature shrieked in pain, its body catching and ripping on the sharp points, but it didn’t stop. It tore itself free and moved faster, making its way towards them.

Darius unleashed a blast of volcanic energy that tore through the street like a tidal wave of heat and colour, light flashing like shadows through the fire. The Dreg reeled, trying to escape, its flesh crackling and blistering.

Nyx advanced in a flash, twisting the space around the Dreg’s limbs, binding it from escaping. The beast thrashed and withered as it struggled against her, slashing out at the invisible chains of her energy.

Darius finished it off with a decisive slash, hurling an eruption of fire that blasted into the creature's chest, burning it from the inside out until nothing but a charred corpse lay on the ground.

Silence echoed for a moment, then cheers erupted from civilians as they peeked from cover.

Shadows of Titan

Celebration spilled out from them. “You saw that, right!?” someone shouted. Reporters were already scrambling onto the scene, cameras activated, lights flashing brightly.

Nyx stood beside Darius as the crowd surged forward, their awe written across their faces. As Darius answered questions Nyx smiled and stayed mostly silent, her eyes trying to adjust to the rapid flashing lights. Her mind was still in a haze as Darius led them back to their transport and gave the nod to depart.

“See! You got this!” he said encouragingly.

She realised she had been mostly silent the whole time and smiled back, trying to think of something to say but falling short.

“The Dregs aren’t people when they’re that far gone,” Darius said in a low voice.

“Whoever that used to be...” He shook his head. “This was for the best.”

Nyx started. “Oh, I wasn’t thinking about that. I wasn’t aware the press would be on the scene so quickly,” she said honestly.

He looked relieved at her response and smiled. “Yeah, they’re ruthless sometimes. But you’re a natural at this!” he said, flicking her on the shoulder.

She smiled up at him. “I didn’t even say anything.”

“Exactly!” he laughed.

The air felt lighter between them the rest of their patrol. She tried to ignore his clear increase of power, and he didn’t mention it. As they worked together, she noticed their energy still worked in tandem. His fire carried faint traces of her energy and vice versa. She tried to stamp down the gnawing worry about Vexal and focused on the tasks at hand. She couldn’t afford to be distracted.

Shadows of Titan

The patrol ended without a hitch. It was fluid, clean, and lethal. She slowly began to feel nothing toward the Dregs as Darius's energy mixed with hers like they'd been fighting side by side for many cycle years, delivering deadly after deadly blow. Darius let her handle containment while he issued commands and handled civilians like it was second nature to him. Truthfully, she liked it that way, not worrying about slipping up and saying something not "Apex" enough.

But by the time Nyx stepped back into the Apex Corps common area she was ready to be alone with her thoughts, but she was greeted by chaos.

"Nyx!" Taryn's voice rang like a bell across the lounge, slicing through the chatter. She nearly launched herself across the room, comtech held high. "You made the news!"

The headline flashed bold and bright:

APEX HEROES SAVE STRATOS LUMINAL FROM RAMPANT DREG!

Beneath it played shaky footage of her and Darius emerging from the ash and smoke, the crowd erupting into cheers.

"Way to go, Nyx!" Seren Kaelith piqued cheerfully, his skin a kaleidoscope of rainbows and colours.

"Look at you!" Taryn beamed, her hair bouncing wildly with her movement. "All shiny and heroic."

Synn drifted over like always, gravity field flickering softly around him. "Not bad at all, Nyx," he said, flicking her shoulder. "First patrol and you're already getting fans. Try not to leave the rest of us in the dust, yeah?"

"Don't be bitter, Synn," Taryn teased. "Your big moment's coming. Maybe a pet phasur needs rescuing from a skynet? Classic hero points."

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The laughter that followed was loud and Synn flipped around demonstrating crested phasur saves. Even Bryn gave a simple “Good work” before going to linger in his normal shadowed corner.

Before they could make their way to the mess area, Dr. Rhea Vaelith entered. The room straightened and the recruits came to attention as she approached Nyx. “That was impressive today, Nyx.” Her voice was calm and gentle and Nyx couldn’t help but feel at ease. “You handled yourself with precision. Keep up the good work.”

The warmth that spread through Nyx’s chest caught her off guard. “Thank you, Doctor,” she said, fighting the smile threatening to take over her face.

The doctor gave her a small nod. “I’ll be scheduling your regular diagnostics. They’ll be sent to your comtech. I want to monitor your development closely.”

“Of course,” Nyx replied, her smile genuine. “Thank you, Doctor. I appreciate the consideration.”

From across the lounge, Lynx Kairen popped his head in and gave a lazy mock salute, his usual razor-edge presence gone. “Not bad for a newbie,” he called, popping back out, the door clicking behind him.

Doctor Vaelith nodded at her once more before following Kairen. As soon as the door hissed shut Taryn groaned dramatically. “Oh great. First the headlines, now the teachers and doctors? We’re officially doomed to obscurity!”

Nyx actually laughed as the chatter picked up around her. Taryn flicked her on the shoulder playfully as they made their way to the mess hall. As they talked and ate, Nyx felt good; even Bryn quit brooding long enough to entertain some of Taryn’s jokes.

Shadows of Titan

As the evening wound down Nyx slipped away. She needed some space. Quiet. Her mind was still buzzing from the mission, her fingers tingled with latent power, and her pulse felt almost a half-step out of rhythm. She wasn't drained; she had in fact hardly used any energy at all today. But the lingering effects of Vexal's powers still thrummed strongly within her, haunting her.

She made her way down the hallways deep in thought and was almost to her room when she saw him.

Darius.

Leaning casually against the wall, his molten eyes tracking her like prey.

"You did good for your first patrol. We made good numbers," he said when she was close enough to hear. She stopped in front of him, tilting her head up to see him fully in the shadows. "High praise. Thank you."

He smirked. "Don't get used to it." A beat passed. "I think we can do better," he said, stepping forward, his tone sharpening.

"Better?" she asked, her brow arched.

"Better coordination. Quicker at containment. Little things," he shrugged.

She nodded but said nothing.

"Next training session is going to have to be at a new location because we toasted the last one," he said casually as he turned and walked down the hallway. "Make sure to bring your best tomorrow." His boots echoed away with his voice.

Nyx felt a strange thrill trickle down her spine as she went into her room. She wondered where they could train that was safer than the Dominion training arena. And then worry hit her so hard it almost took her breath away. What if Darius drained her completely this time? She

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needed to figure out how to be careful while still making sure to surpass Darius's expectations. And after that last debacle of a training session, he was going to expect a lot. She debated on warping to Vexal but she couldn't risk it. Not with her being for sure watched by Bryn and who knows who else. She bit the inside of her cheek as she plopped down at her desk and started absently scrolling through the news feed. She would either need to meet Darius's challenge head-on or come clean about how she maintained her power.

Chapter 13

Helios King sat alone in his private quarters, the dim flicker of his comtech bathing the room in gold-hued shadows. The looping holo-footage played in front of him, relentlessly repeating a ten-second interval. Darius and Nyx, moving like mirrored storm fronts. Their power flowed together well, a very clear evidence of their synergy.

His jaw ticked as it played again. Nyx twisted the air like silk around the creature. Darius followed with volcanic energy that annihilated it with barely a scream. The crowd roared its approval, then the clip started again.

It made him sick to his stomach. He muttered to himself as he stood up, his chair flying back from behind him. His fist flexed, a golden shimmer pulsing beneath his skin. The light crawled up his throat and danced at the edge of his vision, his Solar Resonance flaring in rhythm with his rising agitation.

Shadows of Titan

The footage cut to Nyx's face again, silver eyes faintly aglow, her dark skin haloed in light. She wasn't smiling, he didn't think he had seen her smile once, but the people were still eating her up. A street ghost from nowhere? A cadet barely out of her trials and now patrolling?

Now she was their rising star. Darius Valkyrie and Nyx: *their saviours*.

He hated every bit of it. A sharp knock cracked through the tension. King turned his head slowly as the door slid open tentatively. One of his aides stepped in, spine straight, hands at attention.

"General. Captain Valkyrie is scheduled to train again tomorrow," the aide said carefully. "At five hundred hours. Would you like a report afterwards?"

King stalked toward the aide until he was toe to toe with the trembling man. "No. I'll handle this one myself."

The aide's brow furrowed in confusion, but he saluted and made himself scarce after it was clear no explanation was coming.

As soon as the door slid shut, King started pacing. There was a gut-deep feeling he couldn't shake. Was it fear? He scoffed out loud. He wasn't afraid of anything. He was protecting the Apex Corps and the AAN from an unknown threat. He was protecting their stability, their order. The hierarchy they'd all bled to build.

He was going to be there; he was going to find out what this Nyx woman was. He felt his eye twitch. She was a threat, he'd burn her into the ground himself.

Shadows of Titan

The designated training arena was bathed in the pale morning light as Nyx stepped inside, her comtech's route guidance ending with a final chime. It was quite a distance from the Dominion Training Arena. That facility was still under partial lockdown after what she and Darius had done to it. This place was bigger, far wider, the floors etched with precision-coded energy wells designed to stabilize in the event of catastrophic energy surges. The walls pulsed faintly with layered resonance shielding, newer than what she'd seen even in most Helion spaces.

And waiting at the centre was General Helios King.

His golden armour was already alight, veins of brilliance streaking across its surface like sunfire caught in motion. Etchings along his pauldrons pulsed with Solar Resonance, flaring in time with his breath. The heat hit her first: subtle but insistent.

His eyes locked onto her as soon as she walked in, golden-white irises gleaming, calculating. "Change of plans," General King said flatly as soon as she was within hearing range, the words echoing across the cavernous space. "You're training with me this morning."

Nyx didn't flinch; she was stunned but forced herself to answer. "Yes, General," she said, her voice cool as obsidian glass. But inside, she was roiling. Why him? Why now? What about Darius? He was standing stiffly behind the General, his expression furious.

"I need to know what you're capable of and how it affects the team," King finished.

Darius snapped beside him. "She doesn't need to prove anything! She already—"

"Stand down, Captain Valkyrie," King's voice interrupted coldly. "This isn't about you."

Nyx could see the molten heat rippling off Darius as his energy flared.

"Go," King commanded, his presence causing the massive space to feel suffocating.

Shadows of Titan

Darius stared him down for a second too long before he gave Nyx one last glance and then stormed off to the exit. His boots echoed hard across the alloy as the door sealed shut behind him with a hiss that made Nyx's skin prickle.

Now it was just her and General King. He looked at her with disdain and it reached deep inside her chest, stirring memories she'd rather keep buried far away from this place. She stilled herself and waited, not daring to speak.

The General's voice cut through the silence. "Let's make one thing clear." He turned to her. "I don't like you. I don't trust you. And whatever game you're playing, it ends **here**." He stalked off, tapping a few commands into his comtech.

Nyx let out a breath she had been holding. Was he scared of her? She shook it off and stretched quickly. This was going to burn through her energy, she already knew.

He turned to her, checking to make sure she was ready silently. King snarled at her in one blinding surge, he exploded forward, the training arena illuminating as his mutation unfurled with a roar of light and energy. A searing beam of Solar Resonance burst from his hands, a column of white scorching radiation that screamed through the air with apocalyptic force.

Nyx didn't move. She raised both hands and twisted the space in front of her violently. The Solar beam warped, bent, and veered sideways, slamming into the wall behind her and melting it like wax.

She didn't blink, didn't allow the feelings of déjà vu to creep in. The General didn't let up, either. Radiant blasts cascaded down upon her, hundreds of them, rapid-fire streaks of annihilation. All aimed to overwhelm, overpower, and break her apart.

Shadows of Titan

She moved like ink in water, dodging blasts to reappear behind him, the heat of his resonances alighting the anger in her. With one palm, she raised the floor around him; a forest of jagged spikes burst from the ground, all reaching for his throat.

King moved to dodge the spikes, launching upward in a burst of sunfire, white-gold energy carving through the air as a wave of radiant light scorched the floor below. The heliacal energy howled as it swept towards her, fearsome and unstoppable.

Nyx didn't flinch, though she felt the rising anger in her and tried to calm it down. She lifted her hands again, taking a deep breath. Time stilled around her; the light itself twitched in place as she compressed it down to a single orb, glowing and dangerous. Then she tossed it back to King like a careless gift.

The explosion was instant. King folded his energy to shield himself, the force sending him skidding across the arena, his boots gouging deep into the floor's molten skin.

"Is this all you've got?" Nyx hissed, her ire rising.

King clenched his teeth, his veins bulging and pulsing with light, golden and erratic. He bit out, "**You think this is a joke?**" He roared in anger as he fired again. The heat was so intense the air ignited into solar resonance around him, the strike blasting toward her with the force of a small sun. Nyx warped and reappeared above him. She reshaped the ceiling with a twist of her fingers, tearing it down in a cascade of razored constructs raining down like driving punishment.

King roared in rage, his resonance flaring at full force, incinerating the storm before it reached him. The heat in the air distorted everything, the ground liquefied beneath him into a glowing lake of molten metal.

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She raised her hand again, raising the molten metal with it, writhing and clawing at the General like a living beast. He broke free with an explosion of light, rocketing toward her with his fist ablaze. She didn't move to dodge, but his blow never landed. She caught it with her hands and started rapidly absorbing his energy in a vortex of glowing particles that swirled in her palm. With a painful strain, she sent it back. The blast slammed square into his chest, hurling him sideways across the room. He hit the far wall hard, smoke rising from his armour, breath ragged.

King staggered to his feet, his golden light dimmed and his resonance sputtering like a dying fire.

Nyx came down and started to slowly approach him.

"You're not even trying," King spat, still standing through sheer will and pride.

"Do I need to?" she asked quietly.

He screamed at her. The arena lit up like a second sun and he rose up, pouring everything he had into a final annihilating ray. The temperature spiked as alarms started to go off, the floor rippled and the walls cracked under the heat.

She had no time to dodge or warp, the memory of such fire flashing before her. She raised her hands, shielding herself from the energy, allowing the dark rot in her to swarm around it in a mutated fury of her and Vexal's mutation..

She couldn't fight anymore. Another attack and they would be buried under a molten arena. She didn't want to fight anymore. As the buzz of his power quietly faded away, leaving her slightly exhausted, she watched King drop to one knee.

His light flickered faintly, then died.

Nyx approached him softly, and he looked up at her, his face tight.

"It's **over**," she said, soft but resolute, a flash of inspiration shot through her.

Shadows of Titan

King's jaw flexed, his fist clenching as he glanced around and then down at himself.

There was no denying it.

"I'm not your enemy." She knelt eye to eye with him. "I've looked up to you my whole life. I know what you've done for the Corps. And I know what it cost."

He blinked, clearly taken aback.

"I've strived to be everything you are. Because you are the best." She raised her hands, allowing her Temporal energy to rewind the arena slowly. It groaned under the force but complied shakily.

He watched, his lips in a tight line, before he muttered, "Then stop acting like a threat."

"I will do my best," she chuckled as the last few pieces solidified into place. "But you have to trust me."

Nyx extended her hand to him. He took it begrudgingly and she pulled up his immense weight the best she could. He swayed slightly but didn't fall. "Hold still," she murmured as she noted his bruised and slightly burnt skin.

She placed her hands firmly on his more battered areas and focused her Temporal energy. His skin rewinding to the smooth, golden, untouched skin of an Apex General.

King stared down at himself, flexing a few times. "You can do that?" he asked incredulously.

Nyx gave him a faint smile. "Apparently," she said dryly.

He straightened, the General mask settling back over his face. "The AAN will want your progress report," he said stiffly.

"I'll submit it before hour thirteen," she said, her tone smooth but her mind was racing. Did she make the right decision just now?

Shadows of Titan

King looked at her one last time before he turned to go. His boots clanged against the hard metal floor. “This,” he motioned to the arena, “isn’t over. Don’t mistake your usefulness to the AAN for trust.”

Nyx saluted. “General.”

The door hissed behind King loudly and Nyx let her shoulders slump. She glanced around the arena, making sure it was all in order. She noted that even though King’s damage had been extensive, it had been nothing like when she had synergised with Darius. Maybe that was the problem, she mused as she made her way to the mess hall to fulfil her quota of food consumption.

Why didn’t King just ask to synergise? she wondered. But she was glad he didn’t. She was already on edge, and so many of her memories were threatening to pour through. But she couldn’t break down, not after trying to convince King she was on his side. Her insides physically recoiled at the memory. She had briefly thought to end him there in training, but then what? They would find out where she was from and eradicate all the Dregs and the Undercity as retaliation. No, she had to stick to the plan.

She ate alone hurriedly, counting the different foods she picked up until it seemed like enough, then made her way to the briefing room. Training reports had to be filed in person, but the clerk was, per usual, uninterested and accepted her comtech without looking at her. The clerk pinged it against her system gently and nodded at Nyx briefly, handing it back. Nyx turned quietly and headed to find the other cadets. She could at least join them and make herself known. This was not the time for hiding out in her room, she was sure of that.

Chapter 14

The air down in the Undercity lingered with rot and steam, a metallic tang that clung to your lungs that you couldn't cough out. Vexal hated it here. Not just the smell, or the way the tunnels narrowed the further you descended, but the weight of it, pulling you down deeper and deeper into the very depths of Titan.

His boots splashed through standing sludge, the hum of ageing generators echoing off the warped metal. No surveillance this deep, no patrols. Not even scavengers dared into this sector anymore. The architecture had become wildly unstable, warped and rust-bloated.

He finally reached the door. A slab of steel embedded with old world tech, corroded deep into the wall. He rapped twice.

Silence.

Shadows of Titan

Then with a hiss of hydraulics struggling against their own age, the door peeled open and Vexal stepped swiftly inside.

The old terraforming reactor chamber had been gutted and reborn into something far more twisted. Holo-screens flickered with corrupted feeds on various walls. Cracked tubes of bioluminescent fluid pulsed gently in rhythm with a deep, wet heartbeat. The one that came from the thing in the chair at the room's centre.

Fane Dryst. He sat like a corpse. His frame impossibly thin, bones pressing against veined skin like paper, draped in layers of living shadow and oily black silks that spilled across the floor like bleeding ink. The mechanical throne hissed and clicked with every minor shift of his skeletal fingers. Tubes fed into him at various angles, some biological, others metallic. His presence felt like an oppressive fever dream, power radiating off him in ripples.

"Ah," he rasped, his voice sing-song but cold. "The Rot Saint returns."

Vexal's jaw clenched. He hated that name. He said nothing, just kept walking, his boots echoing off the grated floor.

Across the room, hunched over a nest of makeshift consoles, was Dr. Varian Ekros. His white coat was stained and yellowed at the hem, but his bright teal gloves and red glass lenses glowed at him eerily through the dim light.

"You're late," Ekros snapped, his voice sharp and dripping with contempt. "You shouldn't keep him waiting."

"I don't take orders from you," Vexal snarled, stopping just short of Dryst's throne. Ekros didn't respond, his attention already back on his console.

"Did you bring news?" Dryst asked, his voice soft but poisonous.

Vexal shifted slightly. "It's finished," he said.

Shadows of Titan

Both Ekros and Dryst's eyes snapped to his.

"I got her into the Apex Corps," he continued, his hands sliding into the pockets of his coat. "Her name is Nyx. And she is in, right under King's Solar-polished nose."

Ekros nodded in agreement, his red lenses flashing, a manic gleam in his eye. "She is!" he hissed excitedly. "She is already partnered with Valkyrie."

Vexal felt a slow, satisfied smirk spread across his face. "She's stronger than we expected. She synergised with me twice. She sparred with Darius and King as well."

Dryst stirred, his interest clearly piqued. "Does she know?" the living monster hissed in the shadows.

Vexal's smile vanished. "No."

"Not yet," the cherry-rat said quickly, licking his teeth. "But she will. That kind of power doesn't stay dormant forever."

"She's not dormant," Vexal said darkly. "She's coming into her own. On her own time. King tried to push her today, break her. You saw how that went, **rat**."

A faint twitch ghosted across Dryst's lips, almost a smile but not quite. His raspy voice slithered towards Vexal. "Good. Let's let her bloom, then."

Vexal swallowed hard. The air in the chamber was too warm and too wet. It felt like it was clinging onto his skin and straining his lungs.

"You'll keep her close?" Dryst murmured.

Vexal nodded but didn't bother replying.

Ekros giggled from the corner, a shrill, broken sound. "She doesn't know what she is. The AAN thinks she's an anomaly. But they have no idea. They can't even trace her facility!"

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Vexal glanced at the rat-faced man, his expression darkening. “I thought you erased the records.”

“Nooo,” Ekros said in a sing-song voice, tapping his cherry frames. “And good thing I was there. We would be flying blind otherwise.”

Fane Dryst’s pale eyes snapped open. “Let the Apexes play with her. Sharpen her for us. Then when it's time...”

Vexal bristled.

Dryst noticed immediately. “You’re getting attached.”

The words landed on Vexal like blades. “No,” he said, all too quickly.

Ekros snorted and chortled. “Ah, you always were a softie underneath all that rot.”

“Careful, rat,” he spat in the doctor's direction, fighting the rising memories of when he was a little boy. Standing before this disgusting, massive man. Hoping, begging, for anyone to save him from this hateful man's acidic energy and waste. Fane Solomon Dryst’s mutation, Corrosive Surge, really did affect anything and everything from the inside out. Worse than Vexal’s rot, because at least he could turn his rot off. Not this man; he corroded through everything and everyone. He almost corroded through Vexal when he forced him to synergise with him. His gut twisted in a knot at the memory. They had been compatible. Barely. He had lost more than just his eye in those years.

“So sensitive you always were, Ophedius!” Ekros giggled again, nearly trembling, pale hands wrapped tight around the edge of a rusted console. The veins in his forehead pulsed with excitement. “I saw her power,” he squealed, voice giddy. “I watched her. She’s magnificent. She reshapes space like clay. Can warp. She seems to have no limits to her abilities as long as she has

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someone to synergise with. Which, from the smell of you, Ophedius, you've been taking that on quite well!"

Dryst leaned forward slightly, hushing the squabble immediately with his movement.

"Impossible for someone like you to manage, Vexal. I will take it from here then."

The air froze in his lungs. Vexal couldn't help his posture stiffening. "I have it under control," he snapped. "I got her into the Corps. She trusts me. I'm already pulling her into alignment."

Dryst let out a low, hollow chuckle. It wasn't laughter, though, and nothing was humorous. "Trust you? Vexal?" Dryst's mouth twisted upward. "You've failed me before. Look what it's cost you. Is this really worth your little rot affections? You serve me, Vexal Ophedius Dryst. You are mine. The same way the Myth Project will be mine."

Vexal didn't reply. He couldn't. His throat had gone completely dry. He knew this had been the plan, but it was the first time Dryst had commanded it out loud. "I found her," he finally ground out. "I guided her. She trusts me. She listens to me."

Dryst didn't even bother looking at him. "Listen to you?" he mused softly to Ekros. "Her power is vast... but untamed. She needs a leash. We will siphon what we need. Extract, refine and wield it. After that, I will synergise with her. Then the AAN won't just fall before me. It will be completely erased and I will own the world!"

Ekros nodded manically, already turning toward his cluster of twisted tech. "With siphon nodes embedded at the apex of her field resonance, we could draw unlimited yield. Refraction protocols would amplify the decay-energy loop tenfold. We'd have enough to crack Helion's sky!"

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Dryst smiled thinly. “And then Titan will kneel. As it should have done a long time ago.”

“She’s not your battery,” Vexal said lowly, his voice straining to stay even. “You don’t understand what you are doing. If you push her too far—”

Dryst’s head snapped to him like a wraith spotting movement. “You dare lecture me?”

The room physically darkened as the corrosive energy from Dryst started to rise, choking out what little light there was.

“You think I care what happens to her?” Dryst whispered, acidic spittle flying from his lips. “She is a tool, Ophedius! A means to an end! And you...” Dryst leaned forward, the acidic energy causing tubes around him to hiss violently. “You will bring her to me. Beg her. Seduce her. Lie to her. I don’t care how you do it. She belongs to me.”

Ekros was already typing furiously away. “She’s the answer, Ophedius. The apex of evolution. Once we tap into her, we will be gods!”

Vexal nodded once and turned on his heel, leaving the room without another word, the hydraulic door hissing behind him as he made his escape. He knew he shouldn’t have said anything, but his temper got the best of him.

If Dryst synergised with Myth... He felt bile rise in his throat and he pushed it down as he dialed. And it's not like Dryst would ask nicely again. He always got what he wanted, no matter how cruelly he had to take it.

The Undercity never felt so narrow. So dark. Every tunnel pressed against him as he tried to think. By the time he reached the lift to the hideout, he could barely breathe. Did he only feel this way because they synergised? No. She was different. At the very least, she wasn’t just a project, not just a tool. And the way Fane Dryst treated his tools... Vexal involuntarily touched

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the mechanical side of his face. His boots echoed through the hideout as soon as he hit the ground floor.

“Korric!” he shouted, his voice cracking through the Big O like a blade. The heavy steps resonated immediately. The walls rattled as the seismic juggernaut emerged from one of the halls, brows raised beneath his armour-plated hood.

“What is it?” Korric's deep voice rumbled with concern.

Vexal didn't blink. “Call Lyra,” he said. “Change of plans.”

Lyra materialised to the side of Korric. “Present,” she said seriously, worry etched on her face. Vexal didn't answer. He turned away and pulled out his comtech, the faint blue light illuminating the weary planes on his face, drawing sharp contrast against the blackened decay that spidered across his jaw and neck. He typed without hesitation:

Get here now. We need to talk.

Seconds later, the air next to the door twisted, folding in on itself before Myth stepped clean through like a blade. Her silver eyes swept over them, immediately locking on him. She looked steady, the Apex gear she wore pristine, her violet-streaked raven hair falling loose around her back. He would probably never quite get used to her just appearing like that.

“We need somewhere private. Off-grid.”

“Where?” Lyra asked, crossing her arms, her voice tense.

“Miridan Hollow. On the outer Obscura Noctis Belt.” He pulled out a handheld paper map. Not commonly used, but good if you didn't want to risk being traced. He handed it to Myth.

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Korric grunted, shifting. “You want to go to Miridan, we need to suit up.”

Lyra shifted from foot to foot, she looked unsure and wary.

“We won’t be there long,” Vexal reassured her. “Grab your gear. Myth’s warping us.”

Korric and Lyra were ready in record time, the gear locker losing most of its sturdiest items in the process.

Then the hideout melted into distortion, and the group vanished in a whirl of pressure and dim light. They landed hard in silence. The ash hit them first; the air was thick with it. Gritty, green, slightly acidic, and clinging to everything. They stood on the outskirts of Miridan Hollow. The toxic jungle-like overgrowth that always seemed on fire, the bioluminescent fungi and vines blending in with the smouldering embers, making it impossible to tell one from another. A mostly dead edge of the district, but it was once a terraforming zone. Once that failed, it was turned into a biological weapons lab, and when that failed, an exile zone. The wraiths, all that remained of the biological experiments, moved in and out of the jungle, broken in ribs and warped metal piping hissing off them as they struggled to take shape.

Lyra adjusted her rebreather, muttering, “Sweet Titan, it’s worse than I remember.” Lyra’s patched armour was a dull grey against the knives gleaming at each hip, like twin crescent moons. Korric said nothing as he tightened the straps on his vest, the reinforced steel rebreather humming against his back. The massive Dreg-born loomed in the fog like a tank left to rust. Myth stood, seemingly unaffected. She wasn’t wearing a mask or any breathing gear, and it seemed like the wind didn’t touch her. Instead, it curled around an invisible shield she maintained with eerie ease, her dark hair whipping around her gently, silver eyes scanning the wasteland around her.

“I’ll keep the air clear,” she said in that calm, cool voice she always had.

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A shimmer of distortion spread out in a slow ripple, wrapping the group in a gentle, breathable stillness. Vexal took a deep breath, nodding his approval, while Korric and Lyra both removed their mouthpieces, grateful mutters coming from both of them.

Vexal folded his arms, taking a deep breath, trying to phrase what he was about to say very carefully. “I met with Fane Dryst.”

The name sucked the air from the circle. Lyra’s cocky posture instantly dropped away. “You did what?” she hissed.

Korric grunted, his expression grim. “That walking corpse still has his fangs in you?”

Myth just blinked at him, clearly confused but waiting for an explanation. Vexal cursed lightly, running his hand through his hair. Myth didn’t remember anything and Dryst wasn’t just a common table topic; she had no idea who they were talking about. He turned to her, steeling himself. “Fane Solomon Dryst. An original Omega prototype. A failed one. Discarded by the AAN as a child to the Nocturne Spire, they pretended he didn’t exist.”

Lyra jumped in, voice hard. “He experimented on Dregs. Ripped us apart. Tried to turn us into weapons, and the ones he couldn’t, he siphoned the living energy out of. Hundreds, if not thousands, of Dregs. Kids, too.”

Korric’s fist clenched, the ground trembling slightly in response. “He tortured my brother. Cut him open for weeks before leaving him to die.”

Vexal tried to level his voice. “His energy isn’t natural, it is a mutation called Corrosive Surge. He is nothing but entropy in a humanoid shell.”

Myth finally spoke. “And you met with him...”

“I had no choice,” Vexal said, his voice flat. “The same way he owns all of us. He wants Myth. He wants to siphon your energy, drawing every single last drop. Install resonance nodes in

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your spine and bleed you dry. And when he is done, he'll turn what's left into a mega-bomb to burn Titan to the ground."

Lyra's breath audibly hitched. "You're joking."

Vexal didn't bother answering. Everyone knew, he didn't joke.

Korric was looking at Myth. "You understand what that means, right?" his tone tight.

"He's insane! You'd die. And not quickly. There would be no way we could recover you or your body, either. Not without bringing the Catalyst Wells and Titan down in the process."

Vexal didn't interrupt him; he was right, after all. He had promised he would be there for her, but this was an entirely different scenario than he had prepared for. He had originally lied to Dryst about Myth's power index, but with Ekros at his side, Dryst knew everything that went on in the AAN. Even more than Vexal did.

"Insane or not, it's real and it's happening," Vexal snapped, his voice fraying at the edges. "Ekros is Dryst's lapdog. He practically bows at his feet and he swears he can take her power and amplify it. If that's true, he'll make Dryst unstoppable."

Korric's eyes darkened beneath the grim shadow of his helmet. "And what did you tell them?"

Vexal's jaw flexed. "Nothing they didn't already know. But Dryst gave me an order. Bring her in. There was no 'or else'."

Silence dropped over them like a lead curtain. The only sound was the distant wails of some long-lost wraiths roaming through the desolate sector.

"Why are you telling me this?" Myth asked, her voice steady, but he could feel her emotions beneath it.

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Vexal locked eyes with her, her dark lashes a sharp contrast to her silver eyes. He could see the pressure building behind them. “Because I don’t want that to happen to you,” he said finally.

Lyra scoffed, arms crossed tight. “Since when did we have the strength to go against *the* Fane Dryst?”

“We don’t!” Vexal snapped, spinning toward her. “You know exactly what Dryst is capable of.” He turned to Korric. “You know he’d rip Titan to the core if it meant getting what he wanted. He also has a direct in with the AAN. The truth is, we are wildly outmatched.”

Lyra stared at him, the smirk and snappy attitude long gone. Her lips pressed into a thin line. “So what the hell do we do?”

He looked to Myth, but she hadn’t moved. She stood dead still, but the shimmer around her hummed loudly now. He mentally prepared and replaced his rebreather as the silence stretched taut like a wire. Korrick and Lyra hastily followed suit.

“You’re telling me,” she said finally, her voice almost too soft for him to hear, “that they just want to siphon me then throw me away? Right now?”

Her voice cracked slightly, but Vexal didn’t say anything. He didn’t have to.

“To tear me open. Use me. Until I’m just—” Her voice broke. “**Nothing?**”

The word snapped like a cable and the ground beneath her boots cracked abruptly. Spiderwebs of deep fissures burst from under her feet, tearing through the black soil like claws of a wraith. Something metallic under the seismic plates screamed in response, a guttural screech that made Lyra flinch into him and Korric brace himself in front of her.

“Myth,” Vexal said quickly, making sure Korric had Lyra before he took a step forward. “Don’t—”

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“No!” she screamed at him, her voice like a whip slicing through the air. The space around her flickered violently and the ground started to warp. Ash lifted from the ground, fissures tore open in grotesque spirals, while chunks of scorched earth began to levitate. He dodged left to allow his decay energy to dust the pieces of the falling remnants of old Dreg machines as the plates beneath their feet began bending into unnatural shapes, his decay unable to keep up.

“You’re going to let them use me?” Myth cried out. Her eyes were blank and white, silver tears of starlight streaking down her ebony skin.

Vexal felt a true pang of panic as he watched her power bleed from her like ink into water. Thick black tendrils writhing out from her skin, clawing into the ground, feeding on everything they touched. He heard Korric struggle, the man’s ability to stay anchored being extremely affected by the fact there was no solid ground.

He tried to open his mouth to tell her no, but as soon as he did, ash and acid burned his throat and blinded his eyes, his rebreather breaking into bits from the onslaught. He was thrown to the ground, pieces of debris smashing into him, bruising him and definitely breaking something. He struggled to his feet in time to see the jungle verge in the distance start to crack and warp, displaced wraiths and vines screaming alike, trying to escape. He knew sector alarms had to be screaming and they were quickly running out of time. He could see Lyra peeking around Korric, who was braced behind his knees. Her eyes clearly said, “*Do something,*” but the air around him was thick as iron and every breath felt like swallowing gravel. His internal cybernetics started to tear apart and he felt blood pour down his face.

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He rolled over, allowing his energy to pour into the ground, pushing his body up steadily through the roaring winds. He felt his skin start to fry around his eye, the metal, electricity and ash melting together.

The sky above had darkened, the gas clouds had multiplied and churned with black toxic haze. Lightning from the surge protectors forked down all around him as he dodged barely. The closer he got to her, the slower it felt like the debris rained down, then it was harmless ash.

Her eyes were blank and she was shaking, arms out and rigid. He dropped beside her, wrapping his arms around her tightly, her body shaking him to the bone painfully, but he only pulled her closer. “I won’t let anything happen to you,” he said, his voice barely a rasp. The acidic air was starting to make his brain buzz unfamiliarly, but he shook it away.

“Myth. I’ve got you. But you have to **stop**,” he said, half-pleading, half-demanding.

Her arms slowly lowered, wrapping around him. Sobs racked her body as the tendrils slowly slithered back into her skin. They drifted down to the cracked earth, his arms still around her tightly. But she was holding him more now. Pain wracked through his body and he could barely see, his left eye completely gone.

The sky returned to its sickly grey, but the air remained hollow. He struggled to get to his feet. “Sector... Patrol,” he huffed, wincing. Myth quickly came up under his arm and Korric grabbed his other, looking at Myth wearily.

All around them the sector howled; siren wails echoed like dying animals. They started distant at first, but they quickly became sharper, reaching full deployment. Distorted announcements crackled through the half-broken sector speakers in languages no one spoke anymore. Lights pulsed crimson in the distance, bleeding into the clouds overhead.

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Without a word, Myth reached for the others, her power flaring, and warped them all out. In an instant, the world snapped, and he fought a wave of vertigo so strong he wanted to vomit. He collapsed backward onto her bed, breathing a heavy sigh, his body going limp against the mess of rumpled sheets. For a moment he thought it might really be the end. His vision tunnelled, the edges of the room fading in and out as the blackness curled at the corners of his mind.

He felt small and broken, his breathing slowly being drowned out by fluid in his lungs. A voice cut through the stillness.

“What have you *done*?” Lyra whispered, her voice cracking as she dropped to her knees. Korric didn’t speak. He stood at the foot of the bed like a statue, his gloved hands braced against his legs. Even the ground under his boots was still; he was probably holding it together by sheer force of will, Vexal mused hazily.

Myth was on her knees beside the bed, hands shaking. Her silver eyes were wide, tear tracks of starlight streaked her face. She reached out with a trembling finger, touched his cheek, and pulled it back with a soft gasp. Her hand was slick with black, viscous blood that clung to her skin like oil.

“No... no, no, no,” she whimpered, her voice splintering. Her whole body began to tremble as she looked down at him, the tears coming faster. She hovered her hands over him, as if afraid to touch him again. “What have I done?” she whispered.

“You need to go,” his voice came out in a gurgled rasp. Lyra choked back a cry as he tried to gesture toward the door, but his right arm was a stringy, mangled mess of tendons and muscle. He blinked as he watched it flop lifelessly back down on the bed.

When... had that happened?

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Myth's hands moved towards him again, her breathing ragged.

They would send Apex squads, he knew it. To Miridan Hollow. Whatever she'd just unleashed, her little temper tantrum wouldn't go unnoticed. Every drone, every scan tower, every Aegis patrol in the sector was probably scrambling right now to triangulate ground zero.

He tried to speak again, to warn her, to warn them, but darkness surged behind his eyes.

He felt her hands on his chest; they were burning hot. In a painful, terrifying heat that seared through his body. His skin lit up with a painful sensation. It was too much, too fast. His mind started swarming as the pain changed, cracked, then vanished.

He gasped, the air rushing into his lungs sweet and dense. Something popped loudly inside his chest. Then another. Then bone, sinew, tissues. The feeling was unnatural and very unnerving, but his body was knitting itself back together, cell by cell, nerve by nerve. His rot energy roared back into him like a gas fire breaking through deadwood. His muscles spasmed, knitting together; his joints realigned. He gritted his teeth as his shoulder slammed itself back into its socket. His spine lit up with pressure and his breath caught in his throat. He slowly let it out as he sat up gently. His hand subconsciously went to his face, then both sides of it. It was smooth. Whole. He ran his palms across his ribs, his abdomen, as he slowly opened his eyes. He blinked twice, the sudden light stinging slightly. He lurched up to the small mirror bolted crookedly on the wall. His reflection stared back.

Both eyes looked back, perfect, grey, and sharp. His skin was smooth. His hair healthy and shining in the faint light.

"You healed me?" He was barely able to comprehend what he was seeing. He turned to Myth, but she hadn't moved. She sat on the floor, hunched over, staring down. Her shoulders shook and tears still dripped soundlessly from her eyes.

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Behind them, Lyra and Korric stood in dumbfounded silence. Vexal barely looked at them. He pointed to the door. “Go to HP2,” he said lowly. “I’ll meet you there.”

They hesitated, then slowly, without a word, they left. He knew he didn’t have to tell them not to say a word to anyone; they knew how dangerous their situation had gotten over the past hour.

As soon as the door clicked shut, he crossed the space in two steps, dropped to a crouch, and pulled Myth off the floor and into his lap in one fluid motion. She crumpled into his arms, her body shaking. “I’m so sorry, Vexal,” she choked, voice broken. “I’m so sorry... I didn’t mean to—I didn’t know—”

He shushed her gently as he held her tightly. He didn’t know what to say; his mind was still reeling from what had just happened. He had thought he was definitely a goner, but now... He shook his head. He had to figure something out. Fast. If Fane discovered she could heal, then he would stop at nothing to get her immediately. And Fane Dryst healed and at full power? Titan would have no choice but to bow. Bow or be destroyed. He couldn’t think about that right now. He had to make sure she hadn’t drained herself. He glanced down at her; she had finally stopped crying as hard, and he noticed she seemed tired.

“Are you okay?” he asked her, tilting his head so he could see her more clearly.

She didn’t move at first. Then she leaned back slightly, silver eyes dull beneath her lashes, her mouth tight, unreadable.

“I know you didn’t mean to...” Vexal said carefully. “But look, you healed me. Thank you. I mean that. But... you need to get back.”

Her gaze shifted, narrowing slightly. “Why?”

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“Because this kind of power spike and damage... a sector-wide quake with sirens firing across five districts? It’s all hands on deck. Questions will be asked. Not many people can cause this kind of damage. You have to be there when they start forming answers. Smile. Blend in. Throw them off.”

Myth stared at him for a long moment, her head finally nodding, her eyes accepting he was right. Then, without a sound, she vanished. His arms felt cold from the abrupt loss and he stared at his lap a moment. Then he scrubbed a hand through his hair and without a second glance stalked out. He had places to be.

He was out of the Big O and through the underlayers of the city like smoke, cutting into side alleys and sealed access doors, riding the old tram line beneath the drainage corridors until the neon haze of the Spineheart Market bled into view. The streets were a green-hued, technicolour fever dream this deep after curfew. Smoke curled from burners, clubs pulsing with erratic strobe light, bodies glittering with dyes and wraps. Street vendors shouted goods for sale that would never be spoken of during daylight hours, toys that only the riskiest dare buy. All the while the living heart of the Mossbeast thrummed to the beat of the music, the underground chambers causing an eerie echo into the night.

Hollow Pulse Two, or HP2, was buried behind a chrome-etched gate shaped like an open mouth, its flickering signage coded for insiders only. The bouncer outside gave Vexal a single look before letting him through.

The bass inside hit like a body blow. Everything was pulsing around him. The walls, the floor, even the air. Lights spiralled in fractal bursts, throwing silhouettes against walls smeared with digital graffiti. Synergy pods lined one wall, where Apex hopefuls and Dreg-elite

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synergised, their bodies arching with pleasure or pain, maybe both. A mist of narcotic vapour curled overhead, thick with musk and trace minerals meant to stimulate mutation flow.

He passed by a group of masked dancers writhing in a zero-g bubble. A tank filled with bioluminescent water held a couple fusing mid-synergy, glowing from the inside. He ignored them, looking for his designated chamber, which was tucked behind a sealed sound wall. The room inside was still. Neither of them spoke when he entered. Lyra sat cross-legged, naked on the couch, a half-empty drink forgotten beside her. Her expression was blank, face tilted toward the floor, one leg jittering subconsciously. Her knives lay on the table, crescents shining wickedly in the dim light.

Korric sat beside her, naked as well, elbows on his knees, breathing mask resting in his massive hand. His eyes flicked toward Vexal, but he didn't speak.

Vexal quickly discarded his clothes and ordered a drink. For a long moment they sat there in silence. The synergy chamber was dim and hazed with violet mist, the walls pulsing faintly with embedded resonance lines. No cameras. No drones. Just the raw hum of energy cycling through the room like a second heartbeat.

Lyra was the first to speak. Not surprisingly.

“Is she even human?” she said, voice rising fast. “Vexal, that wasn’t just a flashcrack. That wasn’t spinning out. She could’ve **killed all of us!** Over some bad *news*?” Her voice screeched at the end, brittle and high.

Korric pulled her onto his lap, one massive arm curling around her without a word of disagreement. His voice rumbled low. “If Lyra hadn’t been able to phase through that second collapse, she’d be dead. Even I could barely anchor in.”

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Vexal exhaled, slow and silent, pulling a glowing glass from the wall dispenser and nodding while taking a long drink.

Lyra wasn't done. "And she healed you. You've never—" She broke off, jabbing a finger toward him. "You know you haven't had an eye in how many cycle years? Twenty?"

Vexal shook his head, still silent.

"I'm worried," Lyra said, curling closer to Korric's massive chest. "You said... he... wanted her already. But if he even sees a glimpse of what she can really do..."

"She almost levelled a district," Korric said, his voice uncertain. "What happens next time? What if you're not there to pull her out? What if there is no pulling her back?"

Vexal leaned into the moss bench behind him; the muscles along his ribs still had a phantom ache from where Myth's power had crushed him. His voice was careful when it came. "You are both right. So what do you suggest I do? Hand her over? Kill her myself?"

"Don't be dramatic," Lyra snapped.

"Then what?" he asked calmly. "You said it yourself. It's not a sustainable plan. You think I don't know that?"

"Then why did you tell her at all?" she bit back.

Vexal finally met her eyes, trying to swallow his temper down. "Because Ekros will. You think that psycho wouldn't find an opening to whisper in her ear the second he gets a chance? With the rat at his beck and call, I had no choice. I'd rather at least control the narrative. That meltdown at Nocturne was barely containable. I almost died. If that had happened in the core of Helion Prime, she'd be locked up and immediately voided. At best." He shook his head. "They'd call it a reactor rupture or some natural catastrophe or other. But you, and you, and I, all know the truth. And we don't abandon her."

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To his surprise, Korric nodded.

“I say then, we stay with her,” he rumbled. “Whatever she is, she’s one of ours now.”

Lyra turned, ready to argue, but Korric gently took her chin in his hand. “We have Vexal. She trusts him and that matters.” His eyes flicked toward Vexal. “We know what set her off. We know what she is in part. But she hasn’t even lived a full decade, Lyra. She’s like a newborn with a plasma cannon.”

“Exactly,” Vexal said. “She’s unpredictable, yes. But so are all of us. You’ve seen how the AAN classifies us. Like tools. Weapons. Accidents waiting to happen. We don’t even get the dignity of names, just codes and containment levels.”

He shifted, the faint light glinting across his bare chest and thighs. “Myth’s infiltration is more than a mission now. It’s protection. If the AAN finds out what she can do, though, she will not be recruited. She will be seized, like the Vaelith family.”

The name landed hard. Everyone knew what happened to the Vaelith line. A family of natural-born healers. True healers. Rounded up one by one. Drained, spliced, and branded as state resources. Then voided, politically honoured, and biologically harvested. Any energy type with regeneration capability was considered invaluable.

Lyra’s voice was barely audible. “But if he gets to her, it doesn’t matter what he does, Titan will burn.” She sat up, running a hand through her damp hair. “If the AAN gets her, then we’re all under them for good. So the only option is us.” She gestured around the room. “And I mean, even though she hurt you, she did save you.”

Vexal nodded. “She did.” He stood, stretching his arms and examining himself for any bruising, but finding none. “She did this,” he said, gesturing to his frame. “And I’ve never felt stronger. My energy channels feel quadrupled. I have absolute control over my mutation. She

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amplified me when she healed me.” He flexed his fingers, watching the energy shimmer between them.

“I haven’t even used my energy yet, but I know I’ve Tiered up. If she could do this for all of us? In a fight we would stand a chance. A real one.”

Lyra chewed her lip. “What happens if she turns on us?”

“What happens if *we* turn on us?” Vexal asked back. “This isn’t just winning anymore. I’m not going to lie to you. We are in survival mode. He wants her and if he gets her, we die. The AAN will find out in a matter of time and she will be forced to pick a side. If she sides with us, we are safe and have everything we ever dreamed. If she sides with them, then it's over. I didn’t know what kind of power she had or I would have never let her go into the Apex Corps. But it’s too late to do anything about that. So it is do or die.” He looked at them both. “There are only two threats alive that could hope to match her Tier. One, in his current state, is no match unless he synergised with her or forcibly drained her. I don’t think he could get to her forcibly, but he would try to synergise with her if he did. The other... is Commander Thal Voxx.”

The name settled like lead in the room.

Korric broke the silence first. “Then we support her.”

Vexal nodded. “Exactly. And, alone, I will tell her exactly what we are dealing with when I have more info. Maybe what she has done for me she can do for you. That would give us at least a fighting chance individually if we are smart. Which leads me to this.” He stood, rolling his shoulder, the resonance of his energy flickering along his spine as he stepped toward the centre of the room.

“We synergise. Then we go into every corner of the Undercity. We need to recruit an army.”